

Hank Gerba, PhD

PROFILE

I hold a PhD in Film & Media Studies from Stanford University, and have nearly a decade of storytelling experience in interactive media. I am an expert in linear and interactive narrative theory, both using traditional (branching narrative, nodal structures) and emerging technologies and techniques (generative AI).

EDUCATION

Stanford University, Stanford CA – PhD in Film & Media Studies (2024)

Stanford University, Stanford CA – MA in Film & Media Studies (2020)

Reed College, Portland OR – BA in Art History (2016)

EXPERIENCE

STRATEGIST OF NARRATIVE TECHNOLOGIES, THE WALT DISNEY COMPANY – 2025-PRESENT

I work with creative and technical teams to design and evolve the studio's narrative design technologies—the tools, workflows, and frameworks that support how stories, worlds, and characters are developed. The role spans writers' rooms, studio technology, and emerging media, translating creative intent into roadmaps, prototypes, and practices that connect film, immersive, and interactive storytelling.

MULTIPLE ROLES, ENTERTAINMENT TECHNOLOGY CENTER, UNIVERSITY OF SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA – 2016-PRESENT

ETC is a unique think tank where studio executives collaborate to look around the corner, in part by commissioning demonstrator projects. Currently Lead Researcher on the "Narrative Context Protocol" project (Disney, Epic, NBCUniversal, Amazon, and Dolby), to design and preview the future of author-based narrative design using generative AI. Additionally, I was Narrative Advisor for two films pioneering AI workflows. Previously, I was Associate Producer on *Wonder Buffalo: The VR Experience*, an Emmy-nominated VR short, Researcher, where I wrote several white papers for entertainment executives concerning the relationship between AI and storytelling, and Reporter, helping to produce yearly CTO-level reports on the Consumer Electronics Show (CES).

PHD STUDENT, STANFORD UNIVERSITY – 2018-2024

Produced award-winning research in media studies. Organized high-profile conferences and speaker series. Liaised between students and faculty as graduate student representative, and served as secretary to a special interest group in philosophy and theory. Held fellowships at Stanford's Human-Centered AI (HAI) institute and the Center for Spatial and Textual Analysis (CESTA). Graduated with the Christopher Meier Prize, the Art & Art History Department's highest award for a graduate student.

MULTIPLE ROLES, HANSON ROBOTICS – 2016-2019

As **Writer**, produced narrative scripts and speeches for Sophia the Robot. As **Project Manager**, led a team of engineers, writers, and animators to upgrade Sophia the Robot's physical and conversational capabilities. As **Robot Operator**, liaised with event coordinators, wrote and programmed Sophia's speeches, and operated the robot live. Gained proficiency in communicating about AI and other technologies to professional, governmental, and popular audiences.